



BEFORE

White Southerners badly misjudged both the significance of cotton to the British economy, and the continuing importance of British anti-slavery.

SOUTHERN WEALTH AND VULNERABILITY

Historians have sometimes characterized the antebellum South as a backward slave society, in comparison to the industrializing North. This is not altogether fair. The South did, after all, have a significant role to play in the **industrialization of Great Britain** through the export of cotton to textile manufacturers in northern England. The South also generated more than half of U.S. export earnings before the war (see [North and South diverge](#)). Nevertheless, many future Confederates failed to realize that relying too much on the production of a **single cash crop** made them vulnerable to the rise of alternate sources of supply.

ABOLITIONIST MOVEMENT

The modern anti-slavery movement had begun among Quakers based in England, and **Britain had abolished slavery** through a program of compensated emancipation in the British West Indies in the 1830s. The Royal Navy also devoted substantial resources to patrol operations off the African coast to **suppress the slave trade**. Confederates underestimated the importance of this anti-slavery legacy in Britain.

According to the Confederates who believed in the power of “King Cotton,” the fact that Britain’s valuable textile industry depended on Southern cotton meant that Britain would inevitably side with the South. James Hammond, a South Carolinian, famously declared in 1858 that “England would topple headlong and carry the whole civilized world with her, save the South,” if it was deprived of cotton supplies for three years. When war broke out in 1861, Confederates thus hoped to exert pressure on Great Britain by refusing to export cotton, believing that the resulting economic pain would force Britain to use the power of the Royal Navy to break the Union blockade.

More perceptive Confederates realized that they should not rely on foreign powers to win their independence. During the war’s first year, Lee grumbled about excessive hopes for foreign aid and declared that “we must make up our minds to fight our battles ourselves.”

As it turned out, the British had built up large stockpiles of cotton because of bumper crops before the war, and the Confederate self-embargo also led British mill owners to look to alternative sources in Egypt and India. Finally, and most crucially, the British